Under these circumstances, it is no wonder that the atheist movement which calls religion an arbitrary delusion invented by power-hungry priests and which has nothing but words of derision for the pious faith in a supreme power above man, is eagerly taking advantage of the progress of scientific knowledge; allegedly in alliance with natural science, the movement continues to spread at an ever quickening pace its disruptive influence over all nations and classes of mankind. I need not go here into a more detailed discussion of the fact that the victory of atheism would not only destroy the most valuable treasures of our civilization, but—what is even worse —would annihilate the very hope for a better future.

Thus, Marguerite's question to the man to whom she gave her love and trust gains a most profound significance also for those who anxiously endeavor to find out whether the progress of natural sciences is actually bringing about a destruction of true religion.

If we study Faust's concise reply, spoken with all care and tenderness of feeling, we find that we cannot give it here as our own, for a double reason: First, we must remember that this reply, both in form and content, is designed for the power of comprehension of a simple uneducated girl, and is therefore not meant to impress the intellect as well as the emotions and the imagination. But then—and this consideration is of a more decisive importance—we must bear in mind that these words are spoken by a Faust ruled by sensual desire, a confederate of Mephistopheles. I am sure that the redeemed Faust, whom we meet at the end of the second part, would give a somewhat different answer to Marguerite's question. But I do not presume to conjecture on the secrets which the poet chose to keep permanently as his own. I prefer to attempt to cast some light, from the perspective of one trained in the spirit of exact scientific research, on the question of whether and to what extent a truly religious attitude is compatible with the facts of knowledge gained through natural science—or to express it more concisely: Whether a person trained in natural science can be truly religious at the same time.

For this purpose, first of all let us discuss two special questions, quite separately from each other. The first one is: What demands does religion make on the beliefs of its followers, and what are the characteristics of a genuine religious attitude? The second question is: What is the nature of the laws natural science teaches us, and what truths does it regard as indubitable?

Once we shall have answered these two questions, we shall be in the position to decide whether and to what extent the demands of religion are compatible with those of natural science, and therefore, whether religion and natural science can exist side by side without clashing with each other.

II